Consumer Outage Preparedness and Electrical Safety

SYNTHETIC EDUCATIONAL DOCUMENT — NOT AN OFFICIAL SOURCE

Purpose: Provide background material for retrieval and chatbot testing in the SmartGrid AI prototype.

This synthetic consumer guide provides general preparedness information. It is not a substitute for local emergency management, utility instructions, medical advice, or product safety directions.

1. Before an outage

Keep flashlights, spare batteries, drinking water, shelf-stable food, a charged power bank, and a battery-powered radio where appropriate. Keep important contact information available offline. Households that rely on electrically powered medical equipment should discuss a backup plan with their healthcare provider and utility.

2. During an outage

Use flashlights rather than candles where possible. Keep refrigerator and freezer doors closed. Unplug sensitive electronics if advised or if power quality is unstable. Follow local emergency announcements and the utility's outage map or reporting channel.

3. Downed power lines

Assume every downed wire is energized. Stay far away, warn others to keep clear, and contact emergency services or the utility. Do not touch a wire, fence, tree, vehicle, or object that may be in contact with a line.

4. Generator safety

Never operate a portable generator indoors, in a garage, or near doors, windows, or vents. Generators produce carbon monoxide, which can be deadly. Follow the manufacturer's instructions, use properly rated outdoor extension equipment, and have transfer equipment installed by a qualified professional.

5. Food and medicines

Food safety depends on time and temperature. Follow current public-health guidance for refrigerated and frozen food after an outage. People who need temperature-controlled medicines should ask a pharmacist or healthcare professional about safe storage and backup arrangements.

6. Extreme heat

Use cooling centers or other safe locations if a home becomes dangerously hot. Check on older adults, infants, people with disabilities, and people with relevant health risks. Seek urgent help for signs of heat illness.

7. After power returns

Wait for stable restoration before reconnecting sensitive equipment if advised. Check for damaged cords, water intrusion, or unusual smells. Report hazards to the appropriate utility or emergency service.

End of synthetic document. Verify operational facts with current official sources before real-world use.